

Keyboard Heist

Every scene, across 13 playthroughs that together cover all 42

This is a print copy of the whole story as it stands. Rather than one branching tree, it is laid out as 13 separate straight-through readings ("lines"), each running from the opening ticket to an ending or a dead end. Between the 13 of them, every one of the 42 scenes appears at least once. A scene reached by more than one line is only printed the first time it appears, with a note where it repeats.

Line 1: 23 scenes, ends at "The plateau" (real ending: "The plateau")

Line 2: 18 scenes, ends at "Keep running." (dead end: "Not the hero")

Line 3: 11 scenes, ends at "Skip it. Nobody checks." (dead end: "Asset not found")

Line 4: 3 scenes, ends at "Take it. Right now." (dead end: "The spare")

Line 5: 7 scenes, ends at "Let Mrs. Cox keep going." (dead end: "Method")

Line 6: 6 scenes, ends at "Forget it. Use your mother in Ohio." (dead end: "Long distance")

Line 7: 9 scenes, ends at "Ask him to show you." (real ending: "Eleven years")

Line 8: 9 scenes, ends at "Tell him no." (real ending: "The first no")

Line 9: 9 scenes, ends at "Report him." (dead end: "The fall guy")

Line 10: 6 scenes, ends at "Borrow it for the weekend." (dead end: "Monday")

Line 11: 5 scenes, ends at "Take the sabbatical." (dead end: "Paid leave")

Line 12: 7 scenes, ends at "Tell them everything." (real ending: "The one who didn't laugh")

Line 13: 3 scenes, ends at "Call in sick Friday." (dead end: "Get well soon")

Line 1

23 scenes · ends at “The plateau” (real ending: “The plateau”)

Quick printer help?

(no illustration, this is the opening scene)

From: Daniel Hall, CEO

Subject: Quick printer help?

Hey! Having trouble getting the new printer working. Think it needs a driver? Whenever you have a minute. Appreciate you!

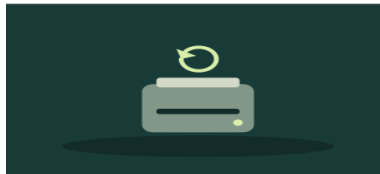
You’re the IT Support Manager. You’ve spent the last few months waking up, fixing problems, going home, and waiting until it’s reasonable to go to bed. Nothing is especially wrong. Nothing is especially interesting. You’ve reached the plateau, apparently, and the view is mostly Outlook.

Then a ticket pops up...

A printer driver. You hate those.

→ **Reply, “Have you tried restarting the printer?”**

Have you tried restarting the printer?



the scene’s illustration

Daniel replies in eleven seconds. “Oh! Good idea!” A minute later: “That worked!! You’re a genius. Appreciate you!”

The ticket closes at 4:49 p.m. It took no skill at all.

Then, a second email, all staff: “Please join me Friday at 3 p.m. in congratulating our IT Support Manager, Employee of the Month! There will be granola bars.”

You have never won anything. You have never wanted to.

→ **Go to the ceremony.**

The ceremony



the scene's illustration

Forty people clap. Marcy, Daniel's assistant, made a banner. It says CONGRATULATIONS, ROB. Your name is not Rob.

Daniel hands you a plaque and a granola bar. "Would you like to say a few words?"

The whole room is looking at you with its whole face. It's the most attention you've had in years. You wait to feel it.

→ Say "thank you" and sit down.

Say "thank you" and sit down.



the scene's illustration

You say thank you. You sit down. There is a tray of granola bars. There is nothing else.

You eat two. You have never felt so appreciated. You have never felt so far away.

Afterward, Daniel catches you by the elevator. "Come by my office before you go. I have something for you. It's a granola bar."

→ **Head to his office.**

Head to his office.



the scene's illustration

Forty-three seconds to Daniel's office. His door is open, because his door is always open.

He looks up and his whole face reorganizes into welcome. "Hey! Gosh, thanks for coming down. Did you eat? I have a granola bar."

You did eat. You decline. He apologizes for the ticket, for the printer, for having a printer at all.

There's a Bible verse on a Post-it stuck to his monitor. A framed photo of his kids on the desk.

He offers you his chair. His phone lights up. "Sorry, gotta grab this. Holler if you need anything." He steps out. The door doesn't quite close.

You put your hands on the keyboard because your hands have to go somewhere.

You type your name. It's a nothing keyboard, the kind companies buy in bulk for executives. You type your name again.

You've been typing on keyboards for twenty-two years. You have never noticed a keyboard before. You are noticing this keyboard.

You type a whole sentence: "Something is wrong with me." You backspace it. The backspace also feels wonderful.

Daniel is still on the phone. Your hands are still on the keyboard.

→ **Stand up. Walk away. Never think about this again.**

Stand up. Walk away. Never think about this again.



the scene's illustration

You say goodbye to Daniel. You say goodbye to the keyboard, silently, like an idiot.

You go home. You do not think about it. You think about it in the shower. You think about it at dinner.

The next morning, at your desk, you open a blank email and type: "Dear Daniel, I quit." It feels wonderful.

You backspace it. You type it again. Your cursor hovers over Send.

→ **Send it.**

The resignation



the scene's illustration

You send it. Your heart does something it hasn't done in months.

Thirty seconds later your phone rings. “Oh my gosh. Are you okay? Is it the printer?”

Daniel is at your desk in ninety seconds. He pulls up the visitor chair. He listens for two hours. He does not once look at his phone.

He offers a sabbatical, a raise, a therapist named Carol, and a granola bar. “I’d rather lose a printer than a person,” he says.

You could take it. You could take it back.

→ **Say it was a typo.**

Say it was a typo.



the scene's illustration

“It was a typo,” you say.

Daniel reads the email. It says, in full, “Dear Daniel, I quit.” He looks at you for a long moment. “A typo,” he says gently. “Okay.”

He believes you. He hugs you anyway. He smells like granola.

It was the best ninety seconds you’ve had all year, and you didn’t even leave. You want to feel it again. You’re not sure how.

→ **Figure out how.**

The plan



the scene's illustration

You can’t stop thinking about the keyboard. Dinner, TV, the usual nothing. Except your fingers keep typing on the couch cushion.

You look it up. Full-size. Black and gray. \$149.99. Four and a half stars. One reviewer wrote, “It’s a keyboard.” You buy one.

It arrives in a box big enough for a small pizza. You type your name at the kitchen table. Nothing. Same model, same clack. It has to be his. Some of his soul got into that one, or something. An x factor you cannot explain, and

it draws you. Well. Now you have a decoy.

You're early the next morning. You open a spreadsheet. Column A: Daniel's schedule. Column B: Things that could go wrong. It's the most alive you've felt in months, and it's a crime. Or it will be.

IT can go anywhere. Nobody asks why. Daniel eats lunch at 12:15 and leaves his door open. Always. His assistant, Marcy, sits outside it and sees everything.

Over her shoulder, her calendar: the company retreat, next Friday. Daniel brings his own keyboard to everything. She calls it "the founding keyboard." He started the company on it. Once it leaves the building, it's gone.

→ **Just ask him about it.**

Just ask him about it.



the scene's illustration

You ask Daniel where he got the keyboard, in the most innocent voice you own.

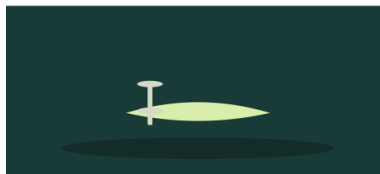
He lights up like you've asked about his kids. "Oh, gosh, this old thing? Sit. Sit!"

He bought it in a garage, on a Tuesday, for \$150, with a partner who quit two years later to open a kayak shop. He typed his first invoice on it. He has typed every invoice since.

It's the first time anyone has talked to you in weeks without a ticket number. Somewhere in your bag, the decoy is very, very quiet.

→ **Let him finish.**

The garage



the scene's illustration

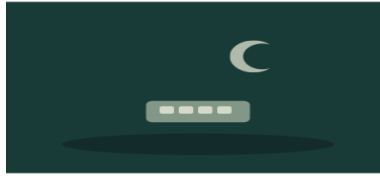
Thirty minutes later, he's still going. You know about the kayak shop. You know about his first customer, a dentist named Phil, and Phil's very specific ideas about fonts.

"You know what?" Daniel says. He looks at the keyboard. "I've had it long enough. I think it's time."

He holds it out to you with both hands. It's the thing you wanted. He's just giving it to you.

→ **Take it.**

The founding keyboard



the scene's illustration

He hands it over like a sleeping baby. You carry it home in both hands. It has typed a thousand invoices. You plug it in at the kitchen table.

You type your name. It's a keyboard. By the door, in your bag, its twin sits in silence. You now own two of the same keyboard. Neither feels like anything.

The worst part is that he gave it to you. You had a whole plan. You feel worse than if you'd stolen it.

At 2:14 a.m. you wake up. Something in the kitchen is typing.

→ **Go look.**

Go look.



the scene's illustration

The keyboard is typing. Nothing is touching it. The screen is filling up.

Invoices. Client names you've never heard. Amounts with too many digits. Every one of them dated next Tuesday.

You look up the companies. None of them exist.

You add the amounts, because you're the kind of person who adds the amounts. It comes to just under a hundred million dollars.

It has typed every invoice since the garage. Daniel told you that himself. He was proud of it.

→ **Take it back to him.**

Take it back to him.



the scene's illustration

You put it on his desk and tell him what it did. You rehearsed this on the drive in. You're expecting panic.

He lights up. "Oh, good! I was hoping it would like you."

He explains it cheerfully, the same way he told you the garage story. Except he never bought it in a garage. He found it there, already typing. He hasn't done any actual work in eleven years. The company is real, the money is real, and the work was never real.

His name also isn't Daniel Hall. It is Danal, seventh and most evil wizard of Xeon, a realm from which unwavering capitalism was first spawned. He mentions this while hunting for the granola bars.

"That's money laundering," you say. "Is it?" he says, delighted, as though you've taught him something. "Do I still call you Daniel?" "Oh, please do. I love it here."

He's evil the way a spreadsheet is evil. He's never once had a single thing to worry about. That's what you've been looking at this whole time. That's the face you wanted.

→ **Walk out and pretend you never saw it.**

Walk out and pretend you never saw it.



the scene's illustration

You don't say anything. You just stand up and walk out.

He doesn't stop you. From the hallway you can hear him humming.

By lunch you've decided that none of it happened. There's no realm. There's no Xeon. There's a nice man with a good keyboard, and it's sitting on his desk where you can see it.

You still want it. That's the part that doesn't go away.

→ **Get back to the plan.**

The outage



the scene's illustration

Daniel leaves for a meeting. His office is empty. You make it to the doorway. Marcy looks up. You crouch and examine a cable that doesn't exist. "Everything okay?" "Cable." She nods. Cables are a thing.

The next day, you take down the internet for "an emergency patch." The building goes quiet, then loud. Ten people wander toward your desk holding their laptops like sick pets.

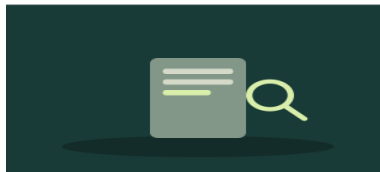
Marcy, who lives in her inbox, comes down herself. You tell her it'll be back in two minutes. She thanks you. She goes to the break room for a snack.

You have two minutes. You walk into Daniel's office. The keyboard is right there.

Next to it, on paper, because the internet is down: his retreat packing list. "Keyboard" is underlined twice.

→ **Back out. Think.**

The grandmother



the scene's illustration

You can't steal it at the retreat. A cabin in the woods, forty coworkers, nowhere to hide. Once the keyboard leaves the building, it's gone.

The retreat has to be canceled. You can't cancel it. Daniel can.

Daniel hates leaving anyone out. Last year he canceled the retreat because one intern was allergic to the trees at the cabin.

All you need is a reason you can't go. A sick relative. You have a mother in Ohio, who is fine and picks up her phone. Or you could hire a grandmother.

You post an ad: "Small family role. Elderly woman. \$75/hour. No questions." Three people reply. The first is a college student in a wig. They probably thought it was for a play. The second is a real grandmother, so old she doesn't even know how to improvise a lie.

The third introduces herself as Mrs. Cox. She reads the brief, asks about your childhood, and tears up. You haven't told her anything yet.

→ **Hire Mrs. Cox.**

The visit



the scene's illustration

You tell Daniel your grandmother is very sick and you can't make the retreat. You look at the floor. You're better at this than you should be.

He puts a hand over his heart. "Then we're not going. Nobody gets left out." Then he asks where she is. He'd like to visit.

Daniel arrives with flowers and a casserole. Mrs. Cox is propped up in a bed you rented by the hour. She knows your middle name. She knows your childhood dog's name. You don't remember telling her.

Daniel takes her hand and prays. She squeezes back. She's crying real tears. "You're a good grandkid," she says to you. She means it more than you can bear.

He sends the email: "Family comes first. The retreat is canceled. Please keep our teammate's grandmother in your prayers." Marcy replies all with a heart. Forty people follow.

→ **Pay her and move on.**

The audit



the scene's illustration

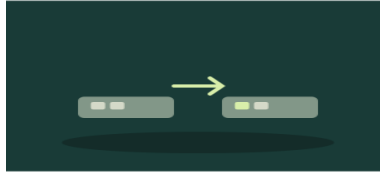
You paid Mrs. Cox \$150 in cash in a parking lot. She asked for a good review and left. The room cost almost as much. Add the decoy, and you've spent three keyboards' worth of money to steal one keyboard.

Then, a new email, all staff: an asset audit. Every keyboard, every monitor, every stapler, scanned and logged.

Every keyboard is tagged. Yours isn't. The moment anyone scans your decoy, it's over. You have exactly one day.

→ **Make a tag.**

The swap



the scene's illustration

The supply closet. An asset tag is a barcode and a serial number. You copy one and change a digit. The night cleaner asks if you're working late. "Inventory." He does not ask about the barcode.

The auditor arrives at nine sharp with a scanner, a clipboard, and a face like an unopened envelope. He counts everything twice. He likes you. You're the only one who answers his questions with numbers, which is worse.

You give him the tour, steering him away from Daniel's office. He steers back. It is the last item on his list. You get there first.

The office is empty. The decoy goes on the desk. The real keyboard goes on the chair, for a second, while you straighten the cable. Footsteps. The auditor is in the doorway, scanner up.

He scans the keyboard on the desk. The forged tag beeps green. You have never been prouder of anything. "Well," he says. He stops. He puts a hand to his chest. He starts to wheeze.

→ **Look at him.**

The choice



the scene's illustration

He drops to one knee. His scanner clatters. He's gasping like a man who's run out of a word.

The keyboard is on the chair behind you. He's on the floor now. For one second, you look at the keyboard.

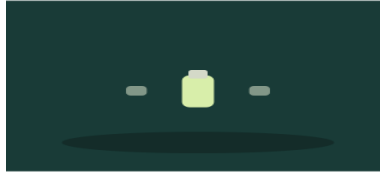
You are shocked. Shocked that you looked at it at all. That it took you a whole second to look back at him. You feel guilty in a way you didn't know you could.

You grab the keyboard and run anyway. Down the hall, past a fern and a poster that says TEAMWORK. Something skitters under your shoe. You look down. It's an inhaler.

"Dang," you say.

→ **Go back with the inhaler.**

The lie



the scene's illustration

You slide back into the office on your knees. You press the inhaler into his hand. “You dropped this,” you say. “Ten seconds ago. I saw it.”

He breathes. He breathes again. He nods, eyes wet. He believes you completely.

He sits against the desk. He sees the keyboard in your arms. “Why did you grab the keyboard?” “I don’t know,” you say. “I wasn’t thinking about it. I just had it.”

It’s almost true. He decides what it means. “You grabbed what was in your hands and you came back,” he says, like he’s explaining you to yourself. He assumes you would never have let him die over a keyboard. That lands harder than the inhaler.

By evening, everyone knows about the inhaler. Nobody knows about the keyboard, which is in your bag. You should feel guilty. You do. You rationalize: the company wants happy employees. You are an employee. You are happy. Aren’t you?

Your phone buzzes. Daniel: “Heard what you did today. Thank you. You saved a man’s life.”

→ **Go home.**

The plateau



the scene's illustration

The keyboard is on your kitchen table. It’s plugged in. Nobody is cheering. The refrigerator hums.

You type your name. It appears on the screen. It feels like a keyboard. It always did. What you felt in Daniel’s office was never the keyboard.

You wait for the rest of it. The part where it was worth it. You give it a minute. You give it a week.

That was the whole thing. That was all of it.

Nothing is especially wrong. Nothing is especially interesting. You’ve reached the plateau, apparently, and the view is mostly Outlook.

Line 2

18 scenes · ends at “Keep running.” (dead end: “Not the hero”)

Quick printer help?

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Have you tried restarting the printer?

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The ceremony

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Say a few words.



the scene's illustration

You say, “I’ve been really bored for a long time.” The room goes silent.

Then everyone laughs. Someone whoops. Daniel wipes his eyes. “Oh my gosh, you’re so funny.” You get a standing ovation. Forty people believe it was a joke.

Jordan, from Accounts Payable, doesn’t believe it. They wait until the room clears, then find you at your desk. “I wasn’t laughing,” they say.

You don’t know what to say back. For once, that’s fine.

→ **Get a drink after work.**

Get a drink after work.



the scene's illustration

The bar is loud enough that you don’t have to fill every silence. Jordan orders something with too many syllables. You order a beer.

They ask what you actually do, since “IT Support Manager” apparently explains nothing. You tell them about the ticket queue, the passwords, the printer that hates everyone equally.

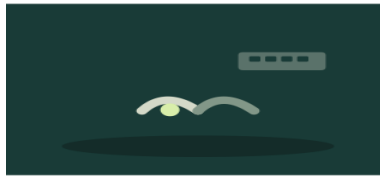
You almost tell them what the joke at the ceremony actually meant. You get as far as “It’s not really a joke. It’s more like” and then stop, because you don’t know how to finish that sentence without sounding insane.

“Like what?” they ask. “Nothing,” you say. “Long week.” They let it go, which you notice, and like.

Two hours later you’re still there. Neither of you has checked a phone once.

→ **See them again.**

See them again.



the scene's illustration

Three weeks in, you know Jordan’s coffee order, their sister’s name, the fact that they cry at commercials but not at anything that’s actually sad.

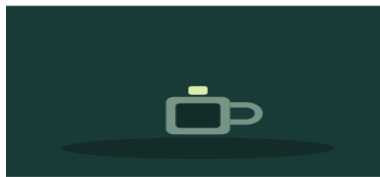
It’s good. It’s better than good. You keep noticing that you’re not bored, which is its own kind of strange, like finding a room in your house you didn’t know was there.

Then one night, half listening to a story about Jordan’s sister’s wedding, you notice the old feeling creeping back in. The plateau. The one from before all of this.

Jordan notices you’ve gone somewhere else. “Where’d you go?” they ask.

→ **Say you’re just tired.**

Say you’re just tired.



the scene's illustration

“Just tired,” you say. Jordan doesn’t believe you, but they let it go this time, and the next time, and the time after that.

You keep letting things go. Eventually there’s nothing left to hold.

Two months later, Jordan’s toothbrush is gone from the bathroom, and you don’t remember watching them take it. You just notice the empty cup where it stood.

You cry once, brief and confusing. Then you think about something else.

→ **Think about something else.**

The plan

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Just ask him about it.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The garage

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Say you couldn't possibly.



the scene's illustration

You say you couldn't possibly. Daniel insists. You say it again. It costs you more than you expected.

He puts it back on the desk, a little hurt, and hands you a granola bar to make up for it.

In your bag, the decoy has never felt heavier. You eat the granola bar. It's a really good granola bar.

You're still doing this. You're just going to feel worse about it.

→ **Back to the plan.**

The outage

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The grandmother

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The visit

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The audit

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The swap

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The choice

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Keep running.



the scene's illustration

You keep running. Past the fern, past TEAMWORK, past Marcy, who is coming down the hall with a granola bar.

She finds the auditor on the floor. She finds the inhaler under the fern. He is fine. He is also very clear about who ran.

You have the keyboard for twenty-two hours. It is on your kitchen table. It feels like nothing.

At nine a.m., HR is waiting by your desk. Daniel stands behind them. He looks so disappointed you almost feel something.

Line 3

11 scenes · ends at “Skip it. Nobody checks.” (dead end: “Asset not found”)

Quick printer help?

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Look up the printer’s model in inventory.



the scene’s illustration

You look up the printer’s model. It’s one you’ve fixed a hundred times. You find the driver, push it to Daniel’s laptop, and the printer wakes up with a small, proud beep.

Ticket closed at 4:52. You’re very good at your job.

Daniel replies in nine seconds. “You’re a lifesaver!! Come by, I want to thank you in person. I have a granola bar for you!”

→ **Head to his office.**

Head to his office.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Stand up. Walk away. Never think about this again.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Save it as a draft.



the scene’s illustration

You save it as a draft. It joins fourteen others. The oldest is from 2021 and just says “Dear Daniel,” which is somehow the saddest one.

It wasn't quitting you liked. It was the feeling. You've only had it one other time this year, with your hands on a keyboard that wasn't yours.

→ **Look it up.**

The plan

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Skip it. Nobody checks.



the scene's illustration

You skip the tag. You do the swap at lunch. Nobody checks, you tell yourself.

The auditor checks. He scans the keyboard on Daniel's desk. It beeps once. Red. "Asset not found," says the scanner, very calmly.

He looks at the keyboard. He looks at you. He has seen this before, and he is sad about it. He calls Daniel in.

Daniel arrives holding a granola bar. He looks at the keyboard, then at you. He is heartbroken. "I just wish you'd asked." You are asked to leave. The real keyboard was in your bag the whole time. It feels like nothing.

Line 4

3 scenes · ends at “Take it. Right now.” (dead end: “The spare”)

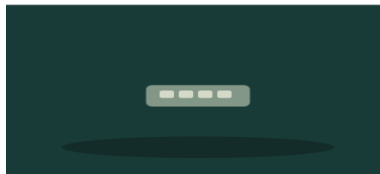
Quick printer help?

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Head to his office.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Take it. Right now.



the scene's illustration

You pick it up. It weighs almost nothing. You walk out holding it in both hands, like a casserole.

Daniel is in the hallway, phone already lowered. “Oh! What are you doing with that?”

“It’s not working,” you say. “I’ll grab you a different one.”

“Oh no, that happened before!” He’s delighted to help. “Just unplug the little receiver and plug it back in. Don’t even need to reset anything.”

He does it for you, right there in the hallway. It works. Of course it works. “Honestly, keep it! I’ve got a spare in a drawer.” He holds it out to you with both hands.

It slips. It hits the floor. The space bar skates down the hall. Something inside makes a small, final sound.

Daniel looks at it. “Oh. Never mind. I’ll use the spare.”

You go back to your desk, where Outlook is waiting.

Line 5

7 scenes · ends at “Let Mrs. Cox keep going.” (dead end: “Method”)

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Head to his office.

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The plan

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The outage

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The visit

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Let Mrs. Cox keep going.



the scene's illustration

You let Mrs. Cox keep going. She is not a woman who stops. She tells Daniel he reminds her of her late husband, Walter.

By Friday, Daniel has given her the guest room. By Monday, she is at the all-hands, taking notes.

She catches your eye across the conference table and mouths: “You owe me.” She is not wrong.

Nobody else knows. You never get near the keyboard again.

Line 6

6 scenes · ends at “Forget it. Use your mother in Ohio.” (dead end: “Long distance”)

Quick printer help?

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Head to his office.

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The plan

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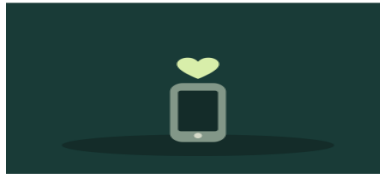
The outage

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The grandmother

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Forget it. Use your mother in Ohio.



the scene's illustration

You tell Daniel your mother is very sick. He is stricken. He is also thorough: he asks for her number, so he can pray with her.

She picks up on the first ring. She is fine. She is also confused. Daniel prays for three minutes. She says “Amen,” because she is polite.

She calls you back at six. “Who is Daniel and why is he so nice to me? Are you okay?”

She’s coming for a long visit. She has already booked the flight. The keyboard is still on Daniel’s desk.

Line 7

9 scenes · ends at “Ask him to show you.” (real ending: “Eleven years”)

Quick printer help?

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Head to his office.

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The plan

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Just ask him about it.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The garage

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The founding keyboard

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Go look.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Take it back to him.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Ask him to show you.



the scene's illustration

He holds out his hand for the decoy in your bag. He knew about it the whole time. He taps it twice and hands it back.

That's the whole spell. No chanting. Nothing catches fire.

That night your keyboard types on its own. In the morning there's money in an account you never opened, from a company that doesn't exist.

You never fix another printer. You never open another ticket. You wake up with nothing to do and nothing wrong, and you smile the way Daniel smiles.

Danal hasn't felt a single thing in centuries. He's never noticed.

Neither will you.

Line 8

9 scenes · ends at “Tell him no.” (real ending: “The first no”)

Quick printer help?

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Head to his office.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The plan

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Just ask him about it.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The garage

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The founding keyboard

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

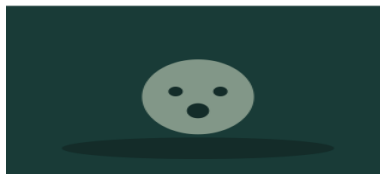
Go look.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Take it back to him.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Tell him no.



the scene's illustration

You tell him no.

He blinks. Nobody’s ever told him no. Not once in eleven years, and not once in the several centuries before that.

His face does something you’ve never seen it do. It stops being delighted. For a moment it’s only surprised.

“Huh,” says Danal, seventh and most evil wizard of Xeon.

You walk back to your desk. The keyboard stays where it is. You don’t look at it.

It’s the first interesting thing that’s happened to either of you in years.

Line 9

9 scenes · ends at “Report him.” (dead end: “The fall guy”)

Quick printer help?

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Head to his office.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The plan

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Just ask him about it.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The garage

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The founding keyboard

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Go look.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Take it back to him.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Report him.



the scene's illustration

You tell him you're going to report him. He isn't worried. He's never worried.

“Oh, you absolutely can,” he says. “But there's no way for me to get caught. There never has been.”

He turns his monitor toward you. Eleven years of invoices. Every one of them is now signed with your name.

You typed it into his keyboard yourself, that first day in his office. Twice.

You're the fall guy. So now you sit at your desk and say nothing, and hope nobody else ever looks closely enough to catch him, because if they do, they'll catch you.

Maybe you shouldn't have taken that ticket.

Line 10

6 scenes · ends at “Borrow it for the weekend.” (dead end: “Monday”)

Quick printer help?

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Head to his office.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The plan

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

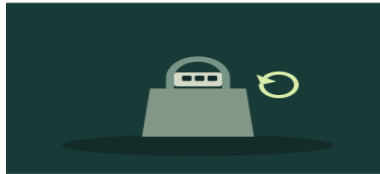
Just ask him about it.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The garage

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Borrow it for the weekend.



the scene's illustration

You take it home for the weekend. You type your name. You type the alphabet. You type a very short letter to nobody. Nothing.

On Monday, you carry it back. “How was it?” Daniel asks.

“Fine,” you say. “It’s a keyboard.” He laughs, delighted, as if you’ve said something profound.

Tomorrow there will be a ticket.

Line 11

5 scenes · ends at “Take the sabbatical.” (dead end: “Paid leave”)

Quick printer help?

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Head to his office.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

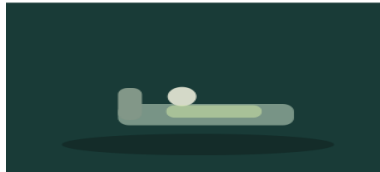
Stand up. Walk away. Never think about this again.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

The resignation

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Take the sabbatical.



the scene's illustration

Six weeks, paid. You buy nothing. You go nowhere. You lie on the couch and wait to feel rested.

On day thirteen, you catch yourself typing on the arm of the couch.

On day forty-two, you go back. There is a ticket.

Line 12

7 scenes · ends at “Tell them everything.” (real ending: “The one who didn’t laugh”)

Quick printer help?

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Have you tried restarting the printer?

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The ceremony

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Say a few words.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Get a drink after work.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

See them again.

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Tell them everything.



the scene’s illustration

So you tell them. Not the joke version, the real one: the plateau, the months of nothing especially wrong and nothing especially interesting, the way even Employee of the Month didn’t touch it. All of it.

Jordan doesn’t laugh, not even a little, which by now you’d expect. They just nod, slowly, like you’ve handed them a much heavier box than they were expecting.

“So that’s what was wrong with you,” they say. Not unkindly.

“That’s wrong with me,” you start to say. Then: “Was.”

Congratulations. You found love. You are no longer bored, worried about tickets, or stuck on the plateau...

Line 13

3 scenes · ends at “Call in sick Friday.” (dead end: “Get well soon”)

Quick printer help?

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Have you tried restarting the printer?

(already shown earlier in this document, repeated here to keep the line intact)

Call in sick Friday.



the scene's illustration

You call in sick. Daniel sends soup. Forty people sign a card. Marcy, Daniel's assistant, brings the plaque to your apartment herself and stays for an hour to tell you about her cat.

You have never been so celebrated. You have never been so bored.